

The online way

What I love most about being Indian, is our welcoming nature. I love belonging to a country where neighbours are often closer to us than family, and friends never need to announce their intentions of coming over. We're a warm, fun-loving culture, and we're really good at making even total strangers feel at home.

One would think such a deep-rooted ethos would also find its way online, but *Digit*, and I, learnt the hard way, that nothing's further from the truth.

The net's become a country of its own, with no laws, and certainly no official moral code of conduct. Of course, this is not something new to any of us, but I'm guilty of being foolish enough to think *all Digit* readers were different.

All of you know we are undertaking new initiatives to connect with each and every one of you – through workshops, reader meets, boot camps and webinars, which we kick-started under the "Eighth Anniversary Carnival" banner. You can turn to page 132 for details of some of the amazing experiences we've had over the past month. However, in this space, I want to talk about the solitary experience that caused me to write this month's column.

One of the webinars, conducted at a press conference – and thus in a relatively uncontrolled environment – was an interview with a global product-design head from a notable technology company. The idea was to get the person to take some time out to connect with our readers, and answer some of the questions they might have. It started disastrously, with no audio for about half an hour. The first thing we learnt from this was to make sure never to take hardware for granted. Half an hour later, we finally did get the audio working, and apologised profusely to both, the participants as well as the guest, but people were restless by then.

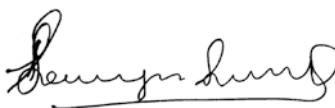
Here's where people hit the proverbial fork in the road, and are usually presented with two choices... In this case, the first is to just forget the initial technical snags and get on to making the most of the opportunity – to get some insights from someone most of us are likely never to meet in the normal course of our lives. The second is to continue to be peeved off and just keep disrupting the webinar. Thankfully, most of the participants chose the former, however, a few chose the

latter. While one person started playing weird sounds through his microphone, others started ridiculing the guest speaker – especially when he stated that he was tired from traveling and had to wrap up the interview quickly. I don't know a single person who would behave that way if this were a face-to-face meeting. What's with the false bravado people show when they're online, and know that they're anonymous?

This is not something any authority will ever be able to control. We're here to learn, and to share insights with you, and we're going to continue to have such meetings – without technical snags – and keep giving you opportunities to interface directly with important industry people. It's our collective responsibility to keep the uninterested away, and outnumber them at every meet.

It is a pity that disruptive elements made that particular meeting much less fruitful for those who were genuinely interested in learning something. My concerns go beyond just netiquette, though. Blogs, for one, have changed the way the citizens of the web behave in general. With information flowing instantaneously around the globe, the false bravado that netizens display under the cover of anonymity has turned into a false sense of knowing. Edward has written previously about Wikipedia and how often it's wrong, and I also find that numerous blogs publish opinions that are riddled with factual holes. Most bloggers are not as open-minded as Wikipedia though, and choose to moderate comments on their blogs. Sometimes, this can end up meaning that a few hundred or thousand vocal netizens can control what a billion internet users just accept to be "the truth", thanks to search engines ranking them high.

This is another reason why it's important that readers like yourself get your answers straight from the industry leaders – keep an eye open for more such webinars and meets, because we're certainly continuing undaunted.



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